

Epidote

△ **Highly transparent**, step-cut, oval epidote gem

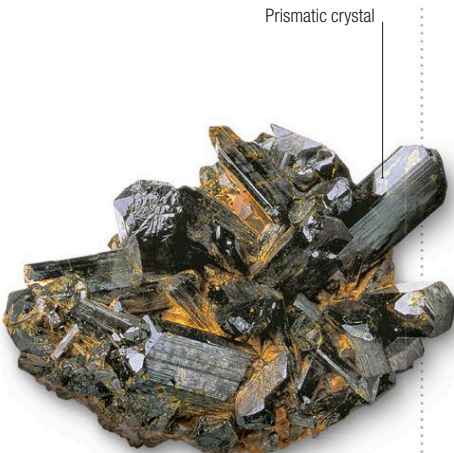
Although epidote is widespread and abundant in metamorphic and granitic rocks, it is less well known as a gemstone. It frequently forms well-developed, transparent crystals that are strongly pleochroic, usually varying in shades of green when viewed from different angles. This requires the cutter to take the orientation of an epidote crystal into consideration when faceting it. It is a fairly fragile mineral with a distinct cleavage, so faceted stones are unsuitable to be made into jewellery and are cut only for collectors.

Specification

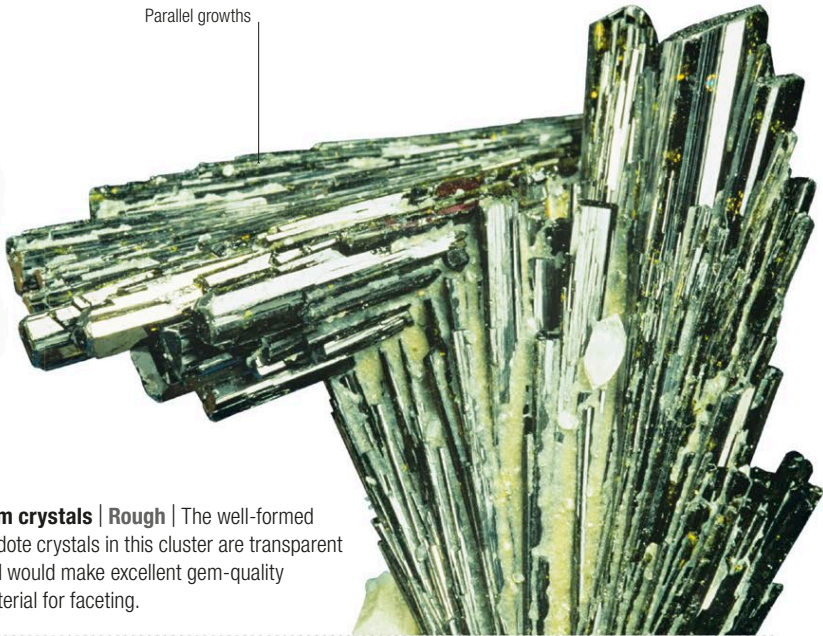
Chemical name Calcium aluminium ferrosilicate | **Formula** $\text{Ca}_2(\text{Fe,Al})_3(\text{SiO}_4)_3(\text{OH})$ | **Colours** Pistachio, mottled pink and green (unakite) | **Structure** Monoclinic | **Hardness** 6–7 | **SG** 3.3–3.5 | **RI** 1.73–1.77 | **Lustre** Vitreous | **Streak** Colourless or greyish | **Locations** Myanmar, France, Norway, Peru, USA, Pakistan



Epidote in matrix | Rough | This elongated specimen consists of a series of long, thin epidote crystals that have grown in a quartz matrix.



Pistachio epidote | Rough | This cluster of long, prismatic, pistachio-green epidote crystals originates from Peru, a source of large amounts of the mineral.



Gem crystals | Rough | The well-formed epidote crystals in this cluster are transparent and would make excellent gem-quality material for faceting.



Mottled unakite | Colour variety | Rock made primarily of epidote, such as this mixture of epidote and feldspar, may be polished or tumbled and sold as unakite.



Brown epidote | Colour variety | Brown epidote is an uncommon colour, and is even more uncommon in faceted gems, as in this rectangular step-cut.

Unakite

A colourful variety

Unakite is an altered granite made up of pink orthoclase feldspar, green epidote, and generally colourless quartz. It is also referred to as epidotized, or epidote, granite. Found in various shades of green and pink, it is usually mottled in appearance; it takes a good polish and is thus used as beads or cabochons, and as eggs, spheres, and animal carvings. Some material called unakite lacks the feldspar and is called epidosite; this is also used as beads and cabochons.



Various beads Strands of colourful semi-precious stones hang in a shop, including those of unakite, top centre.